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DOST ILOCOS REGION, DOST-PCIEERD STRENGTHEN RESEARCH CULTURE THROUGH CAPACITY BUILDING ON R&D PROPOSAL DEVELOPMENT

To strengthen the research and development (R&D) capabilities of academic and research institutions in the Ilocos Region, the Department of Science and Technology Ilocos Region (DOST Ilocos Region), through the Ilocos Consortium for Industry, Energy, and Emerging Technology Research and Development (ICIEERD), in partnership with the DOST-Philippine Council for Industry, Energy and Emerging Technology Research and Development (DOST-PCIEERD), conducted a two-day Capacity Building on DOST R&D Proposal Development on June 17–18, 2026 at Ynad’s Place Hotel and Restaurant, City of San Fernando, La Union. The activity gathered researchers, faculty members, and representatives from State Universities and Colleges (SUCs), private Higher Education Institutions (HEIs), and various research organizations across the

➡️ (TURN TO PAGE 2)



PORTASOL Technology Ensures Cleaner, Faster Drying for Matungo Cacao Farmers



Traditional open-sun drying leaves hard-working farmers at the mercy of unpredictable weather, leading to high post-harvest losses and lower market prices. To address this challenge, the Local Government Unit of Matungao and DOST Lanao del Norte officially sealed their

partnership on June 18 at Matungao Municipal Hall. Led by Mayor Hon. ➡️ (TURN TO PAGE 2)

CCPO Explores Opportunities in Science and Technology Initiatives with DOST Cotabato



The Department of Science and Technology (DOST) SOCCSKSARGEN – Cotabato Provincial Science and Technology Office (PSTO) conducted an orientation on the agency's Programs, Projects, and Activities (PPAs) for the uniformed and non-uniformed personnel of the PNP Cotabato Police Provincial Office (CPPO), led by Provincial Director PCol Ramil B. Hojilla. The activity aimed to enhance the awareness of CPPO personnel on the various science, technology, and innovation (STI)-based opportunities and interventions ➡️ (TURN TO PAGE 3)

PORTASOL Technology Ensures Cleaner, Faster Drying... From page 1



Jaber M. Azis, this collaboration focuses on introducing science-based solutions to secure local food production and protect farmers' livelihoods. To guide the community toward sustainable agriculture, DOST is deploying the Portable Solar Dryer (PORTASOL). This innovative technology directly answers the need for a faster, cleaner drying process. Featuring stackable, enclosed aluminum trays, it protects crops from rain, dust, and pests. Following the signing, DOST conducted a hands-on orientation for the Matungao Integrated Farmers Association to ensure they maximize this tool for their cacao production. Municipal Agriculture Officer Mr. Steward D. Rosiana emphasized that adopting these smart tools reduces hard labor while preserving crop quality. By working closely with local leaders, DOST helps transform traditional farming challenges into highly resilient, profitable, and worry-free livelihoods. DOST continues to walk alongside local leaders and agricultural communities to turn innovation into everyday progress.

Cavite
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Publishing
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CAVITE WISDOM PUBLISHING IS
PUBLISHED WEEKLY EVERY MONDAY

OFFICE ADDRESS:
B18 L14 Ph10 Oxygen St. Dasma 4 Golden City Barangay Salawag,
Dasmariñas City, Cavite 4114 Philippines Cel # 09176275522
Email Ad: wisdom.cavite@gmail.com
Fb Page: Wisdom Newspaper
Website: cavitewisdom.com

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DOST ILOCOS REGION, DOST-PCIEERD STRENGTHEN RESEARCH CULTURE... FROM PAGE 1



region to enhance their competencies in developing responsive, competitive, and fundable R&D proposals aligned with regional and national development priorities. DOST Ilocos Sur Provincial Director Jordan L. Abad delivered the welcome remarks and rationale of the activity, emphasizing the importance of capacitating researchers and institutions in developing R&D proposals that address priority needs and contribute to inclusive development. Meanwhile, Dr. Virgilio P. Manzano Jr President of Mariano Marcos State University (MMSU) and Chairperson of IC-IEERD, highlighted the consortium's role in advancing collaborative research, innovation, and technology-driven development in the region. [The activity featured a series of lecture sessions facilitated by experts from DOST-PCIEERD, namely Ms. Glenda Dorcas T. Sacbibit Supervising Science Research Specialist (SRS); Ms. Elaine P. Haftorn SRS; Mr. Julius L. Mayorga Project Technical Specialist III; Mr. Xyrelle G. Villacote Project Technical Assistant IV (PTA IV); Mr. Lan Carlo L. Balabag PTA IV; and Mr. Abner DoradoPAA V. Discussions covered the overview of DOST R&D priorities and funding mechanisms key elements of a fundable R&D proposal, common challenges and best practices in proposal writing and an orientation on the DOST Project Management Information System (DPMIS). Participants also engaged in guided proposal development workshops, peer review, coaching, and mentoring sessions to further strengthen their research concepts for potential DOST funding support. Mr. Decth-1180 P. Libunao, Assistant Regional Director for Field Operations of DOST Ilocos Region, concluded the session. In his message, he emphasized the vital role of research and innovation in addressing real-world challenges and improving the lives of Filipinos, highlighting DOST Ilocos Region's commitment to ensuring that science and technology create tangible impacts for communities through "Agham na Ramdam". Through initiatives such as this, DOST Ilocos Region and DOST-PCIEERD continue to nurture a stronger research and innovation culture in the region by empowering researchers and institutions to develop impactful R&D projects that contribute to scientific advancement, regional competitiveness, and sustainable development.



**CHIZ SAYS TRANSFER OF FDA
FUNCTIONS TO CLEAR
BOTTLENECK, EASE BUSINESS
COMPLIANCE**

Senator Francis “Chiz” Escudero is eyeing a measure that will transfer several regulatory functions of the Food and Drug Administration (FDA) to other government agencies to make government approval processes more efficient and business compliance easier.

According to Escudero, FDA’s mandate is so broad that its functions have led to overlaps and delays, and as such calls for the redistribution of its powers that would allow specialized departments to handle regulation more efficiently and effectively in a timely manner.

“Sa tingin ko ay masyadong malawak ang kasalukuyang mandato ng FDA ngayon na nagiging dahilan para bumagal at maging kumplikado ang proseso. Mas mainam na ilipat sa tamang ahensya ang ilang mga responsibilidad nito para sa mas mabilis at malinaw ang regulasyon,” Escudero pointed out.

Under his proposal, key functions of the agency would be absorbed by appropriate government agencies. For example, he said, the regulation of fresh food would be transferred to the Department of Agriculture (DA), processed food and cosmetics to the Department of Trade and Industry (DTI), and medicines to the Department of Health (DOH).

“Kung pagkain, sa DA. Kung processed food o cosmetics, sa DTI natin ilagay. Kung gamot naman, sa DOH. Hindi dapat lahat nasa FDA,” Escudero said.

Escudero argued that the redistribution would streamline government functions and reduce overlapping mandates. “Ang FDA ay naging catch all agency sa mahabang panahon. I think, it is about time that we fix this and move some of its functions to the right

departments or offices.”

The Bicolano senator emphasized that his proposed bill aims to ease compliance for businesses while ensuring consumer protection remains intact, saying: “Hindi natin tinatanggal ang regulasyon. Ang ginagawa natin ay inililipat sa mas angkop na ahensya.”

Past efforts have already seen certain FDA functions transferred to other agencies through memoranda of agreement (MOA) and similar arrangements. Some regulatory responsibilities over agricultural products were already moved to the DA. Escudero’s bill, however, seeks to institutionalize this through a law that would effectively transfer FDA’s vast functions to proper government agencies.

Furthermore, the FDA has also drawn concern from industry groups and oversight agencies over delays in processing applications, particularly for emergency medicines.

The Anti-Red Tape Authority or ARTA has reported that the FDA received a high number of complaints among government agencies, citing bottlenecks in its evaluation process. Business groups have pointed to prolonged product registration timelines and complex regulatory requirements as barriers to market entry.

Several countries also operate without a single, catch-all FDA-type regulator. In Singapore, food oversight is handled by the Singapore Food Agency while medicines and cosmetics fall under the Health Sciences Authority. The United Kingdom likewise splits responsibilities among the Food Standards Agency, the Medicines and Healthcare products Regulatory Agency for medicines, and the Department for Business and Trade for cosmetics.

**CCPO Explores
Opportunities in Science
and Technology... From page 1**



being offered by DOST, particularly in the areas of technology-based livelihood development, entrepreneurship, productivity enhancement, community development, and capacity-building initiatives. During the orientation, the DOST Cotabato team presented an overview of the agency's mandate, core functions, and its role in promoting science, technology, and innovation as drivers of inclusive growth and sustainable development. The discussion highlighted several flagship programs, including the Small Enterprise Technology Upgrading Program (SETUP), which assists micro, small, and medium enterprises through technology interventions and innovation support, and the Commu-

nity Empowerment thru Science & Technology (CEST) Program, which delivers science-based solutions to address the needs of underserved and vulnerable communities. The team also introduced other DOST initiatives such as scholarship opportunities, technology transfer programs, STARBOOKS, and community-based technology interventions designed to improve the quality of life of Filipinos. Through this activity, DOST Cotabato and the Cotabato Police Provincial Office strengthened their partnership in promoting public awareness of government programs and fostering a culture of innovation, community development, and citizen empowerment in the Province of Cotabato.

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SHOWBLITZ
By: Charlene Mae
**Sam, sinagot ang isyung
nagka-gf ng influencer;
hindi pa nakaka-move on
kay Rhian**



Umiiwas na si Sam Verzosa na pag-usapan si Rhian Ramos.

Pero wala siyang choice dahil pilit siyang tinatanong tungkol sa ex.

Humarap ang business partners at celebrity entrepreneurs na sina RS Francisco at Sam Verzosa sa ilang entertainment media bilang support sa P-pop groups na Chicser, BILIB and 6ENSE.

“Nahihiya na nga ako sa kanya. It’s been months. Sabi ko nga kay Tito Boy (Abunda), huling beses ko nang pag-uusapan. Nakakahiya. Baka sabihin, wala tayong respeto. Medyo matagal na. Parang binubuhay pa natin ‘yung wala na,” pagdiidin ni Sam.

Tapos na aniya ‘yun. “Respeto ko na rin ‘yun sa kanya,” dagdag ni Sam.

Besides, expired na rin aniya ang contract ni Rhian and Michelle Dee sa Luxxe White kaya umiiwas na raw sana siyang pag-usapan si Rhian.

“Yes, expired na po (ang kontrata bilang mga endors-er). Expired na lahat!” sabi ng isa sa mga owner ng Luxxe White. Maaalalang pinag-usapan ang launching nina Rhian at Michelle sa kanilang kumpanya matapos nilang gawan ng bonggang lamay ang pagbabu ng dati nilang mga produkto.

With matching real cas-

ket noon na ayon kay RS ay tatlong kumpanya ang gumaya sa kanila kaya naman kahit may bashers, hindi sila naapektuhan. Besides aniya, mas ginawa nilang effective ang bagong mga produkto nila.

Sa kasalukuyan ayon kay Sam, pahinga muna ang puso niya kasabay ng pagtanggap na nagkaroon siya ng short relationship sa isang influencer na may anak na. Hinding-hindi raw ‘yun totoo.

Ipinakita pa na hindi niya hindi niya pina-fol-low ang nasabing influencer at wala raw silang common friend.

Katuwiran niya pa: “Mas okay na single na muna ngayon, kasi ang daming uma-sa sa akin, ang dami kong napa-bayaan before, marami tayong inintindi, napunta tayo sa pulitika, kaya ang daming napabayaan. So ngayon, bawi tayo!” sabi ni Sam.

Sa ngayon ay wala na raw silang communication ni Rhian pero aniya handa siyang mag-reach out. “Oo naman, walang problema ‘yon. Pero siyempre, timing nga. Walang problema ‘yung... to be humble, to be a man, walang problema, eh. Time lang. ‘Pag pareho nang nag-heal. Sa totoo lang, mabait na tao si Rhian. Naging maayos ang relationship namin, kumbaga four and a half years, tapos bigla lang may nangyari sa dulo.

“Sa akin, mas pinipili ko na makita ‘yung magaganda, masasaya, kesa ‘yung mga maliliit lang na nangyari na masama. Sometimes ang relationship, mahabang panahon na masaya, maayos, na parang magkakaibigan, na maaayos naman, tapos may nangyari, buong pagkakaibigan n’yo, nasayang. “Para sa akin, darating din ‘yung

time na kapag naintindihan niyo, kung bakit nangyari ‘yon, at na-ka-move on kayo, na-heal kayo,” dagdag pa niyang kuwento sa ilang kaharap na entertainment media.

At doon niya in-amin na hindi pa raw tal-aga siya nakaka-move on.

“Hindi pa rin siguro, honestly, hindi pa nakaka-move on. Hindi pa kami nagkikita in person. I’m just telling you the truth. Siguro, kapag nakita ko siya, magugulat ako, baka may konting kaba, may pain. Hindi ko nga ma-explain,” pag-amin niya pa.

Samantala, kung hindi ni-renew sina Rhian at Michelle, opisyal namang nag-renew ng kanilang endorsement contracts ang tatlo sa pinakinaabangang Pinoy boy groups ngayon — ang fast-rising P-Pop groups na BILIB at 6ENSE, kasama ang origi-nal Pinoy boy group na Chicser.

Mas kilala na ngayon ng kanilang supporters bilang ba-gong “Luxxe Boys,” magkaiba man ang henerasyong kanilang kinaka-tawan, iisa naman ang ipinapakita nilang qualities — talented, di-siplinado, may kumpiyansa sa sar-ili, at laging handang mag-level up.

Patuloy na pinapal-awak ng BILIB ang kanilang fanbase dahil sa world-class per-formances, synchronized cho-reography at feel-good music.

Samantala, mabilis ding umaarangkada ang 6ENSE bilang isa sa mga pinaka-promising na bagong P-Pop boy groups sa bansa.

Kasama rin sa power-house lineup sina Oliver Posadas, Owy Posadas, Ulysses Basa, Clar-ence Villafuerte, Biboy Chua, at Ranz Ongsee ng Chicser, ang origi-nal Pinoy boy group na minahal ng milyun-milyong fans dahil sa kanil-ang viral videos, mall shows, TV appearances at natural na charisma.

Ngayong reunited na sila, handa na ring ipakilala muli ng Chicser ang kanilang grupo sa ba-gong henerasyon ng mga tagahanga.

Ayon kay Frontrow International co-founder RS Francisco, swak na swak ang tat-long grupo sa mensahe ng brand.

“Sila ang representa-syon ng kabataang Pinoy ngay-on. Talented, masisipag, at may self-confidence. Higit sa lahat, nai-inspire nila ang ibang kabata-an na maniwala sa sarili nila. Iyan ang klase ng confidence na ipinag-mamalaki ng Luxxe White,” ani RS na tamad nang mag-showbiz.

Naimpluwensiyahan daw siya ni Gretchen Barretto.

“Parang nawalan tala-ga ako ng gana. Before pandem-ic, bigyan mo ako ng kahit anong role, go ako, kahit hindi mo na ako bayaran. Pero ngayon, parang... I don’t know kung dahil sa age.

“Para sa akin, ‘yung mga kinagigiliwan ko, nag-sa-shine, okay na ‘yon. Even si Gretchen, ganun din, eh.

“Nahawa na ako kay Gretchen!” sabi pa ni RS.

Hindi na nar-aramdaman ng showbiz si Gretchen sa kasalukuyan.

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SPORTS NEWS

Eala ready to test defending champion Swiatek

MANILA, Philippines -- Alex Eala's remarkable rise is no longer measured merely by victories. It is now defined by the growing belief she inspires wherever she plays.

From Miami to Eastbourne and now the manicured lawns of Wimbledon, the 21-year-old Filipina has become one of tennis' biggest crowd favorites. Fans have embraced her fearless style, infectious fighting spirit and refusal to surrender, turning every match into a showcase of her enormous potential. Every tournament seems to produce a breakthrough, every victory another chapter in what is fast becoming one of Philippine sports' greatest stories.

Even with her right leg strapped -- not because of injury but as a preventive measure -- Eala continues to defy expectations. Whoever stands across the net and whatever the surface, she somehow finds another gear, delivering performances that seem even better than the last.

Her comeback victory over Maya Joint, 3-6, 6-2, 6-0, on Thursday was another testament to that resilience. The triumph not only avenged her heartbreaking Eastbourne finals defeat to Joint a year ago, but also made history as Eala became the first Filipina to reach the third round of Wimbledon.

Now comes the biggest test yet. Standing between Eala and a dream quarterfinal berth is none other than World No. 3 and reigning Wimbledon champion Iga Swiatek.

Against a player of Swiatek's caliber, crowd support alone will not be enough. Neither will emotion nor momentum.

To pull off another shocker, Eala will need to produce her most complete performance yet -- serving with precision, attacking with conviction, defending relentlessly and staying mentally composed during the inevitable pressure moments. She must dictate rallies instead of reacting to them, seize every short ball, protect her own serve and embrace the fearless brand of tennis that has carried her this far.

Swiatek herself enters the showdown in commanding form. After surviving a tough three-set opener against Taylor Townsend, the Polish superstar cruised past Karolina Pliskova, 6-1, 6-3, to arrange a third career meeting with the Filipina sensation.

The two have split their previous encounters. In one of the biggest upsets of the 2025 season, Eala -- then ranked just No. 140 -- stunned Swiatek, 6-2, 7-5, in the Miami Open quarterfinals, becoming the first Filipina to reach a WTA 1000 semifinal. That magical run eventually propelled her into her maiden WTA final at Eastbourne.

Swiatek, however, restored order weeks later in Madrid, rallying for a 4-6, 6-4, 6-2 victory. Saturday's showdown offers a fresh twist. It will be their first meeting on grass -- a surface that presents new challenges and perhaps new opportunities.

Eala knows exactly what awaits. "I think it's going to be tough for me," she said after defeating Joint. "I'm going to try to make it tough for her as well."

That hardly sounded like a threat. It sounded more like quiet confidence. "It's a different surface than we've played at before, so I think definitely there should be some

different aspects to the last time," said Eala.

The young Filipina also recognizes the enormity of the challenge. "She's won a Slam on grass. She's won a Slam on clay. She's won a Slam on hard, so I'm expecting a great challenge," she said.

Swiatek, for her part, knows better than to underestimate the player who stunned her in Miami. "I don't particularly know her game on grass," said Swiatek. "Obviously, I know how she plays because we played already."

She also acknowledged the qualities that make Eala one of the tour's most dangerous rising stars. "She has a tricky game. I can assume that on grass it's even more tricky because of the surface. For sure, she's using her strengths, the change of rhythm and everything," said Swiatek. "It will be a good challenge for me because she doesn't give that rhythm."

Those words speak volumes. Eala is no longer viewed simply as an exciting prospect. She has become a legitimate threat capable of unsettling even the world's elite.

That is perhaps her greatest transformation. Whether she pulls off another upset or bows out against one of the game's finest, Eala has already announced herself on tennis' grandest stage. She is no longer just representing Philippine tennis -- she is helping redefine it.

And if she can summon one more fearless performance against the titleholder, another chapter of history may yet be waiting to be written on Wimbledon's famous grass courts.

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